

A STREET GONE MAD

THE NEXT THING I KNEW, MR. BOESKY WAS ARRESTED FOR allegedly having traded on inside information that made him his millions of dollars. Apparently the people from one side of the Chinese Wall in various merger and acquisition departments of banks and brokerage houses had leaked information to people on the other side of the Chinese Wall, and Mr. Boesky was a major beneficiary. Being foretold of numerous upcoming takeovers and deals that inevitably would send stock prices soaring, Mr. Boesky made investing look easy.

I could see why he never called me back. He was wired up by the SEC. God knows what would have happened if they'd recorded me blurting out, "Give me a tip. Tell me something, anything, to rescue my portfolio," which is how I'd planned to put myself at his mercy. By now, my mother-in-law was telling me, "It's a good thing you stayed away from that silly man."

Everyone who'd been desperate to see Mr. Boesky all of a sudden was desperate to avoid him. He was in universal disfavor, the whole of Wall Street was shocked, and there was talk of future indictments. This troubled me a great deal. What if I, too, had acted on inside information in the Bally deal? After all, I'd heard it in the bathroom, and from two of the players in the same game as Mr. Boesky's. That would be a fitting end to my journey: the only insider trader to have lost all his money.

To avert potential problems before they came up, I called the Securities and Exchange Commission office in New York and was put through to Mr. Anthony in the legal interpretation section. I'd talked to him earlier about selling stocks in a garage sale, but